Ke Cheng HSU (Clio)
Department of Economics, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
Clear Water Bay, Kowloon, Hong Kong · +852 6840 9753
khsu@connect.ust.hk · cliohsu1997.github.io

4 November 2026

Faculty Search Committee
Economics and Management School, Wuhan University
Wuhan, Hubei, China

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to apply for the tenure-track Assistant Professor position in the Economics and Management School at Wuhan University. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology. I expect to graduate in June 2027 and can join in Fall 2027. My fields are Empirical Industrial Organization and Digital Economics.

My job market paper, "Designing Return Policy in E-Commerce: A Trade-off between Purchase and Return Efficiency," studies whether a return policy encourages efficient returns and purchases. A stricter policy curbs inefficient returns after delivery, but the lower return rate makes a higher product price more attractive for the seller and can exclude efficient purchases. Using transaction data from a Taobao apparel retailer, I estimate a structural model of purchase, return-shipping insurance, and return decisions under monopoly pricing across six categories. Automatic coverage of return shipping performs better when the margin, net scrap value, and uncertainty are high, because it expands efficient purchases. Optional coverage performs better when those attributes are low, because it curbs excessive returns. A menu that pairs a discounted price with a medium restocking fee balances the two margins and performs better than both insurance policies for most categories.

In other projects, with Pak Hung Au, I study how firms use product design to direct the search of consumers with different search costs. With Kohei Kawaguchi and Kei Kawai, I use Japanese bookstore data to study how resale price maintenance encourages retailers to hold inventory in low-demand states, yet leaves unsold copies that cannot be cleared by cutting the price and are returned. With Ce Bian and Liang Zhao, I study pass-through when products can be returned, and show that a tax can lower the equilibrium price and raise welfare by reducing the return rate.

At HKUST I was a teaching assistant from 2020 to 2025 for undergraduate macroeconomics, the economics of uncertainty and information, and Ph.D. microeconomic theory, with an average evaluation of 4.72/5. In 2026 I designed and lectured the mathematics camp for the MSc in Economics, receiving 4.53/5. I am prepared to teach microeconomic theory, industrial organization, applied microeconomics, information economics, and econometrics from the undergraduate to the Ph.D. level, mathematics for economists through the master's level, and macroeconomics at the undergraduate level.

I submit my CV, job market paper, and research statement with this application. Pak Hung Au, Kohei Kawaguchi, and Kei Kawai will provide letters of recommendation. You can reach me at khsu@connect.ust.hk or +852 6840 9753.

Sincerely,

Ke Cheng HSU
Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Economics, HKUST